TEXORA · LECTURE SHEET

Mood Board

The designer's brief in visual form: one board that fixes a collection's theme, colours, fabrics and feeling before a single garment is drawn — and communicates it to everyone who must build or buy the collection.

AM-4203 · FASHION DESIGN AND PRODUCT ENGINEERING · TOPIC 6 · LEVEL 4 TERM 2

1. What a mood board is

A **mood board** (also called a theme board or concept board) is a composed arrangement of images, colour swatches, fabric pieces, words and sketches that states the **theme** of a coming collection: what it is about, how it should feel, and the visual world it belongs to. It is made at the very start of range building, before garment designs, and it serves two masters: it is the designer's own thinking tool, fixing decisions that would otherwise drift, and it is a communication tool — the one artefact a merchandiser, a buyer, a pattern maker and a client can all read identically.

2. What goes on the board

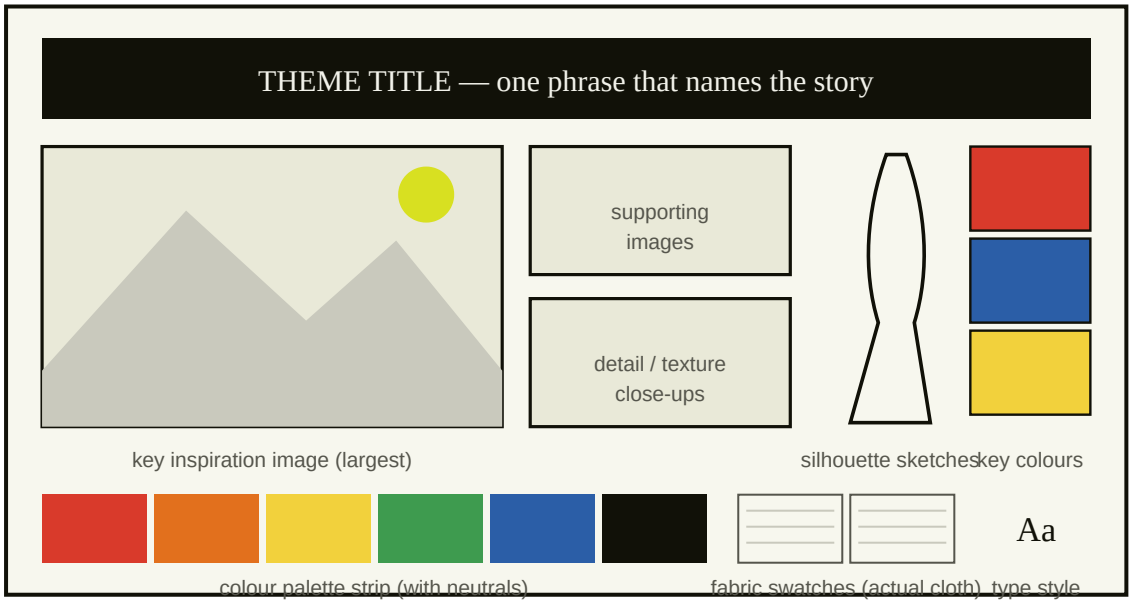


Figure 1 — Anatomy of a mood board. One dominant image carries the mood; everything else — palette, fabrics, silhouettes, type — is evidence for it. A board where all elements are equal in size has no message.

COMPONENT	FUNCTION ON THE BOARD

Theme title and key words	Names the story in a phrase ("Monsoon Coast", "City Tailoring"); key words fix the intended qualities — sharp, faded, ceremonial — against which later choices are tested.
Inspiration images	Photographs and pictures of anything that carries the mood — places, objects, art, architecture, earlier fashion. They are references, not designs to copy.
Colour palette	The collection's colours as actual swatches, arranged in their intended proportions: dominant colours large, accents small — the palette is itself a proportion decision (Topic 5).
Fabric swatches	Real cloth pieces wherever possible: the board must promise only what fabric behaviour can deliver (Topic 4's fitness rule).
Silhouette and detail sketches	First rough garment shapes and details (a collar, a sleeve, a trim) showing how the mood becomes clothing.
Customer reference	An image or description of the intended wearer — the board is judged against a person, not in the abstract (Topic 7 supplies the behaviour behind this).

3. Building the board: the working method

1. **Research and collect widely.** Gather far more material than the board can hold — images, swatches, clippings, objects — from the theme's world.
2. **Edit ruthlessly.** Select only what serves the single story; two themes on one board is no theme. The discarded material is not wasted — it is the editing that creates the message.
3. **Compose by the principles.** One dominant image (emphasis), supporting elements arranged around it with balance and rhythm (Topic 5): the board is itself a design and is judged by the same principles it will impose on the garments.
4. **Fix the palette and fabrics from the board.** Extract the colour strip and swatch set as working documents for dyeing, buying and CAD.
5. **Present and freeze.** The board is presented to the team or client; once approved, it is the reference against which every later design is checked — a design that does not belong on the board does not belong in the range.

4. Physical and digital boards

The traditional board is physical — mounted images and pinned cloth on a presentation board — and keeps one advantage nothing digital replaces: real fabric can be touched, draped and seen in true colour. Digital boards (composed in design or presentation software, or in the same CAD environment as AM-

4202 Study 4) win on speed, sharing, revision and archiving: a board can be sent to a buyer in another country in seconds and revised overnight. Professional practice uses both: digital for development and communication, physical swatches retained wherever colour and hand must be judged exactly.

Glossary

TERM	MEANING
Mood board	The composed visual statement of a collection's theme, colours, fabrics and feeling.
Theme / story	The unifying idea of a collection, named on the board and tested against every design.
Palette	The fixed set of colours for a collection, shown in their intended proportions.
Range	The full set of styles offered for a season, built under one or more themes.

Key points and summary

- The mood board fixes theme, palette, fabrics and feeling before design begins, and communicates them identically to every party.
- Components: title and key words, inspiration images, palette, fabric swatches, silhouette sketches, customer reference.
- Method: collect widely, edit to one story, compose by the design principles, extract working palette/swatches, present and freeze.
- Physical boards judge colour and cloth truthfully; digital boards win on speed and sharing; practice uses both.

Practice

Answer in your own words; brief model answers follow.

1. A student's board carries two unrelated themes and twenty equal-sized images. State the two faults by the method of §3.
2. Why must the palette swatches appear in unequal sizes on a well-composed board?
3. A buyer in another country must approve the theme tomorrow; the fabrics, however, must be judged exactly. Plan the board package.
4. What is the board's role after the range is approved and production begins?

Answer key

1. First, the editing step failed: two themes means no single story, so the board cannot guide selection. Second, composition failed: with no dominant element there is no emphasis, so the viewer cannot tell what the collection is about.
2. Because palette proportions are a design decision: the swatch areas announce which colours dominate the range and which are accents. Equal swatches postpone — and effectively abandon — that decision.
3. Send the digital board immediately for theme approval (speed and sharing), and courier the physical fabric swatches and a printed colour strip in parallel for exact judgement of cloth and colour — the standard combined practice of §4.
4. It becomes the standing reference: samples, prints, trims and bought fabrics are checked against it, and any style that drifts from the theme is caught at sample stage rather than at the buyer's audit.

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